The Dance of Five Blades

An Untold Tale of the Tianxia Succession Wars
Third Year of the Succession Wars
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In the third year of the Succession Wars, as princes fought over a shattered throne and rival kingdoms' banners rose above burning cities, a modest inn stood along a forgotten mountain road. It was a place too insignificant for generals to conquer, too remote for imperial magistrates to govern properly, and too ordinary for the great heroes of the Jianghu to remember. Yet travelers from across Tianxia knew of it, for within its humble walls was brewed a wine whose fragrance could make even the most homesick wanderer forget his sorrows.

The inn was called the Guīyàn Kèzhàn (Returning Swallow).

Its owner, Han Wei, was a stern woman approaching fifty, with sharp eyes, a sharper tongue, and a remarkable talent for remembering unpaid debts. Travelers called her Aunt Han, whether they were related to her or not. She had managed the inn for nearly two decades, surviving harsh winters, wandering bandits, dishonest merchants, and, more recently, the soldiers of three competing armies. She possessed no apparent interest in politics or the affairs of the martial world. As far as her customers knew, Aunt Han cared about three things: her wine, her inn, and her two nieces.

The elder niece, Han Yuelan, was twenty-four years old and possessed a beauty that travelers occasionally mistook for the delicate grace of a court dancer. She had long black hair, dark, expressive eyes, and the slender figure of someone accustomed to carrying heavy wine jars. Her hands bore small scars from years of work, while her feet moved with a natural elegance unusual among ordinary

villagers. The younger, Han Xiaoyu, was nineteen, lively, mischievous, and blessed with a smile capable of softening even Aunt Han's foulest moods.

The sisters had been orphaned many years earlier. Their father had died when they were children, and their mother, Han Yu, had followed him not long afterward. Aunt Han had taken them in, offering them a home beneath the weathered roof of the Returning Swallow. There, the girls had grown up among the scent of fermenting rice, the clatter of porcelain cups, and the stories of wandering merchants. They learned to balance ledgers, prepare meals, serve customers, and brew the inn's famous plum-blossom wine. It was a simple life, and for Xiaoyu, it was enough.

For Yuelan, however, simplicity had always felt like a beautiful cage.

On a cool autumn morning, before the first travelers had risen from their beds, Yuelan stood alone in the courtyard behind the inn. The sun had barely emerged above the eastern mountains, and thin ribbons of mist drifted between the plum trees. She wore a plain white training robe tied at the waist with a faded blue sash. Her long hair was gathered into a high knot, secured with a wooden pin Xiaoyu had carved for her several years earlier.

Strapped across her back was an unusual arrangement of five scabbards, bound together somewhat crudely with leather straps and reinforced with strips of cloth. The contraption resembled a bundle of firewood more than the equipment of a respectable swordswoman. Aunt Han had once suggested commissioning a proper case from a craftsman, but Yuelan refused. The arrangement worked, and she had grown rather fond of its ugliness. Besides, few craftsmen knew how to construct a sheath for five swords that could fly.

Yuelan drew a deep breath, allowing the cold morning air to fill her lungs. She closed her eyes and guided her Qi downward into her dantian, feeling its warmth gather beneath her navel. From there, she directed it outward through her meridians, into her shoulders, arms, wrists, and fingertips. A soft metallic ringing came from her back. One sword slid free. Its blade was narrow and bright,

forged from polished steel that reflected the pale morning sky. It rose slowly above her right shoulder, hovering without support.

Xuánjīn Jiàn (Steel).

Another sword followed, broader and darker than the first, its blade bearing faint golden veins reminiscent of mountain stone.

Hòutǔ Jiàn (Earth).

A third emerged with a subtle crimson shimmer, heat rippling along its edge despite the cool air.

Chìyàn Jiàn (Fire).

The fourth was slender and pale blue, its curved surface catching the drifting mist as though drawing water from the air.

Liúbō Jiàn (Water).

Finally, the fifth sword rose, its dark green hilt ornamented with delicate patterns of twisting branches.

Qīngténg Jiàn (Wood).

These were the Hán Yǔ Wǔjiàn (Five Blades of Han Yu), inherited from Yuelan's mother, and the most precious possessions she owned. The Wǔxíng Tiānwǔ (Fivefold Heavenly Dance) was a martial tradition passed exclusively through the women of her mother's family. Its practitioners believed that women possessed the flexibility, dexterity, and precision required to command multiple blades through the intricate movements of traditional dance. Men, according to the family elders, lacked the necessary grace. Whether this was a profound martial truth or simply an opinion repeated by generations of stubborn women, Yuelan had never been entirely certain. Nevertheless, the tradition was strict.

Daughters inherited their mother's surname, and the secrets of the dance passed on to the oldest, while sons bore their father's name and were expected to find their own path. Over the centuries, the lineage had dwindled. War, marriage, disease, and the jealousy of rival martial sects had reduced a once-respected art to a handful of surviving practitioners.

Yuelan had begun learning at nineteen, using the notes and memories her mother left behind. Her earliest attempts had been disastrous. She could barely lift a single sword without exhausting herself, and on one memorable occasion, she had accidentally sliced through Aunt Han's laundry line, sending freshly washed undergarments fluttering across the courtyard.

Five years later, she could command all five blades… *Somewhat*. She raised her right hand, palm outward, and slowly rotated her wrist. The steel blade turned in the air. She bent her knees and extended her left arm, allowing her body to flow into the opening posture of the Chūnlián Wǔ (Spring Lotus Dance). The water sword followed the curve of her sleeve, gliding around her waist before rising beside her shoulder.

Yuelan stepped forward. One step became two. Two became three. Her hips turned, her sleeves unfurled, and her feet traced an elegant circle across the stones. The swords began to move. When she rotated her hand, a blade spun. When she swung her arm, a sword cut in the same direction. When she extended her fingers, the weapons thrust forward. Her body became the language through which the blades understood her intentions. Fire swept overhead in a brilliant crimson arc. Wood followed beneath it, spiraling gracefully like a vine growing around a tree. Steel flashed through the morning mist, while water curved around Yuelan's shoulders like a flowing ribbon. Earth remained near her feet, moving slowly, heavily, responding to the rooted stances of her dance. The five blades circled their mistress.

Yuelan smiled.

She raised both hands, then spun upon the ball of her right foot. Her sleeves blossomed around her, and the swords spread outward like the petals of an enormous flower. For a brief moment, she appeared less like a martial artist and more like some celestial dancer descended from the heavens. Then she attempted the final sequence. Her right hand turned too quickly. The fire sword surged ahead of the others. Yuelan hurriedly corrected her stance, but the earth blade, responding to the sudden shift of Qi, accelerated in the wrong direction. There was a tremendous crash. A wooden practice dummy exploded into splinters. The earth sword continued through the fence and struck a stack of empty wine jars. Clay shattered across the courtyard.

Yuelan froze. From the second floor came a familiar roar.

"HAN YUELAN!"

Aunt Han leaned through the window, her hair tied in a loose bun and a wooden ladle clenched in one hand.

"HOW MANY TIMES MUST I TELL YOU NOT TO PRACTICE NEAR THE WINE JARS?"

Yuelan lowered her arms. The five swords obediently drifted back toward her, sliding into their respective scabbards with a series of soft metallic clicks.

Yuelan:

"They were empty, Auntie."

Auntie Han:

"THEY WERE GOING TO BE FILLED!"

Yuelan:

"Then technically I've saved you the trouble of washing them."

Aunt Han raised the ladle. Yuelan immediately bowed.

Yuelan:

"I shall repair the fence."

Auntie Han:

"AND BUY NEW JARS!"

Yuelan:

"Yes, Auntie."

Auntie Han:

"AND STOP SMILING!"

From the kitchen doorway came the sound of Xiaoyu laughing:

"Jiejie, that's the third fence this month!"

Yuelan turned indignantly.

Yuelan:

"The second."

Xiaoyu:

"The chicken coop counts."

Yuelan:

"That chicken coop was poorly constructed."

Xiaoyu:

"The chickens disagree!"

Their laughter filled the courtyard, mingling with the morning birdsong. Above them, Aunt Han shook her head and disappeared inside, muttering that the heavens had cursed her with two troublesome girls.

By midday, the Returning Swallow was crowded with travelers. A merchant caravan from the southern provinces occupied three tables, arguing loudly over the rising price of salt. Two wandering monks shared a bowl of noodles near the window. A family fleeing the fighting in the north sat quietly beside the hearth, their possessions piled beneath their chairs.

War had become a constant presence, even here. Three years earlier, when the succession dispute first erupted into open conflict, the mountain road had carried merchants, scholars, and pilgrims. Now refugees outnumbered traders,

and many travelers carried weapons beneath their robes. Every few weeks, soldiers arrived demanding food and wine in the name of whichever prince they served. Aunt Han treated them all the same.

Pay first. Drink afterward. No fighting beneath her roof.

Her Returning Swallow Wine remained famous throughout the surrounding provinces. It was brewed from mountain rice, springwater, wild plum blossoms, and a fermentation starter whose preparation Aunt Han guarded more fiercely than her life savings. The finest batches were aged for years in enormous clay jars deep beneath the inn. Yuelan and Xiaoyu had spent much of their childhood in those cellars. They knew which jars needed turning, which required fresh seals, and which must never be opened without Aunt Han's permission. The largest cellar was carved into the hillside beneath the inn, its vast chambers connected by narrow corridors and supported by thick stone pillars. An old wooden freight elevator, operated by chains and counterweights, carried heavy jars between the lower chambers and an upper storage building farther up the slope. Yuelan had always found the place comforting. It smelled of rice, old wood, and sweet alcohol. It smelled of home.

That afternoon, while Xiaoyu served customers, Yuelan approached Aunt Han at the counter:

Yuelan:

"Auntie."

Auntie Han:

"No."

Yuelan blinked:

"I haven't asked anything."

Auntie Han:

"You have that look."

Yuelan:

"What look?"

Auntie Han:

"The look of a girl preparing to say something foolish."

Yuelan leaned against the counter:

"I'm twenty-four. I've trained for five years."

Auntie Han:

"Congratulations. And destroyed enough furniture to supply a small lumberyard."

Yuelan:

"I can control all five blades."

Auntie Han:

"Then control them away from my jars."

Yuelan sighed:

"Auntie, I want to enter the Jianghu."

Aunt Han stopped writing. Xiaoyu, polishing cups nearby, grinned.

Yuelan:

"I've practiced every day. I've studied Mother's notes. I've mastered the first seven forms, and I can perform the Fivefold Lotus without dropping a single sword."

Auntie Han:

"Except when you're destroying my fence."

Yuelan:

"That was an accident."

Auntie Han:

"So was the roof?"

Yuelan grimaced:

"That roof was old."

Auntie Han:

"It was built last spring!"

Xiaoyu burst into laughter. Yuelan pressed on.

Yuelan:

"The Succession Wars are tearing the country apart. People are suffering. Wulin travel the roads protecting the weak, fighting bandits, and helping those who cannot defend themselves. I could do that. I could make a difference."

Aunt Han slowly closed the ledger:

"What do you know of the Jianghu?"

Yuelan straightened:

"I've heard the stories....Of great heroes, wandering swordsmen, honorable duels—"

Aunt Han gave a humorless laugh:

"Honorable duels... Do you know how many men I've seen die over honor?"

Yuelan hesitated:

"How many?"

Aunt Han:

"Too many."

She paused and continued

"The Jianghu is not a place where good people always defeat wicked men. It is a place where old grudges outlive the people who began them. Where a careless word can start a feud lasting generations. Where a swordsman may save a village one day and burn another the next because someone offered him enough silver."

Yuelan frowned:

"Not everyone is like that."

Aunt Han said quietly:

"No, not everyone."

For a moment, sadness crossed her face. Then she returned to the ledger.

"But enough are."

Yuelan:

"Auntie—"

Aunt Han:

"No."

Yuelan:

"One journey."

Aunt Han:

"No."

Yuelan:

"Just to the next province."

Aunt Han:

"No."

Yuelan:

"Perhaps a month?"

Aunt Han:

"Yuelan."

Yuelan:

"A week?"

Aunt Han looked up:

"Do you wish to spend the rest of the afternoon scrubbing the fermentation jars?"

Yuelan immediately straightened:

"No, Auntie."

Aunt Han:

"Then go help your sister."

Yuelan walked away muttering under her breath. Xiaoyu leaned toward her:

"Seventy-five tomorrow?"

Yuelan:

"Naturally."

Her younger sister giggled:

"You know, if you ever do leave, you'll need someone to carry your things."

Yuelan smiled:

"Are you volunteering?"

Xiaoyu:

"Of course not. I intend to stay here, drink our wine, and become a respectable businesswoman."

Yuelan ruffled her hair:

"Then when I become a famous heroine, I'll return and drink your most expensive wine for free."

Xiaoyu slapped her hand away:

"Absolutely not! Family pays double!"

Their laughter followed them into the kitchen. Neither noticed Aunt Han watching from the counter. Her expression was troubled.

The stranger arrived shortly before sunset. He came walking along the mountain road beneath a broad bamboo hat, dressed in a faded gray robe stained with dust and rain. A long sword hung at his waist, its hilt wrapped in old cloth. He was a broad-shouldered man in his late fifties, with a weather-beaten face, a graying beard, and a scar crossing the bridge of his nose. His boots were worn. His posture was relaxed. But his eyes were sharp.

He paused outside the inn and examined the building for several moments before entering.

Yuelan approached him with a welcoming smile:

"Honored guest, welcome to the Returning Swallow. Food, lodging, or wine?"

The stranger looked at her. Something changed in his expression. "Han Yu's daughter," he murmured.

Yuelan blinked:

"You knew my mother?"

The man hesitated. Then smiled faintly:

"I knew many people, once."

He placed a copper coin on the counter:

"Tell the owner that Bao has come."

Yuelan:

"Bao what?"

Bao:

"Just Bao."

Yuelan:

"Surely you have a family name."

Bao:

"Had one. Left it somewhere along the road."

Yuelan frowned:

"That's rather dramatic."

Bao chuckled:

"Most things in the Jianghu are."

At the mention of the Jianghu, her eyes brightened:

"You're a Wulin?"

Bao:

"Some would say so."

Yuelan:

"How long have you traveled?"

Bao:

"Longer than you've been alive."

Yuelan:

"Have you fought any famous masters?"

Bao:

"Unfortunately."

Yuelan:

"Could you teach me—"

Aunt Han:

"Yuelan!"

Aunt Han stood at the kitchen entrance. Her face had gone pale. Bao slowly rose. For several heartbeats, they simply stared at one another.

Then he bowed:

"Han Wei."

Aunt Han:

"Bao."

Bao:

"Been a long time."

Aunt Han looked toward Yuelan:

"Take your sister downstairs. Check the seals on the new wine."

Yuelan:

"But—"

Aunt Han:

"Now."

Yuelan recognized that tone. She bowed reluctantly and went toward the cellar. But curiosity had always been her greatest weakness. Instead of descending, she slipped into the narrow storage room beside the private dining chamber, where an old crack in the wooden wall allowed sound to pass. She pressed her ear against it.

Inside, Bao spoke quietly:

"He's dead, Wei."

Silence.

Then Aunt Han asked:

"How?"

Bao:

"At Hēilú Dù (Black Reed Ford), soldiers of one of the western courts caught him escorting refugees. They accused him of aiding their enemies."

Aunt Han:

"Did he fight?"

Bao gave a bitter laugh:

"You knew him."

A long silence followed. Bao continued:

"He killed eleven before they brought him down. Even wounded, he refused to surrender."

Aunt Han said nothing.

Bao:

"His last words were about you."

Yuelan heard the scrape of a chair.

Aunt Han:

"What did he say?"

Bao:

"He wanted to know whether you were happy. I told him you had a quiet inn in the mountains. Two girls to raise. Good wine. A peaceful life."

A pause.

"I told him you were happy."

For a long moment, nothing could be heard.

Then Aunt Han whispered:

"Thank you."

Yuelan frowned*: Who was this man?*

Bao continued:

"There's something else."

Aunt Han:

"Of course there is."

Bao:

"They found the old records. The Vermilion Archive."

Aunt Han:

"Impossible."

Yuelan heard Bao lower his voice:

"Not all of it was destroyed. One of the warring courts knows that She Who Wears Many Faces is still alive. They know you served the imperial intelligence office before the dynasty fractured. They know you abandoned the bureau and disappeared into the Jianghu with Shen Zhaoming."

Yuelan's heart began to pound: *Imperial intelligence? Aunt Han?*

Bao continued:

"They believe you still remember the identities of informants, secret routes, hidden agreements, and the names of officials who betrayed the throne before the Succession Wars."

Aunt Han answered coldly:

"That woman died twenty years ago."

Bao:

"Not according to their records."

Aunt Han:

"Then their records are wrong."

Bao:

"Han—"

Aunt Han:

"I left that life behind!"

Bao sighed:

"I know."

Aunt Han's voice rose:

"No, you don't. I followed Zhaoming into the Jianghu because I believed we could live freely. I believed we could do some good. And for years, we did. But every village we saved led to another feud. Every life we spared returned with another sword. He wanted to keep wandering, keep fighting, keep proving himself against the world."

Her voice softened.

"I wanted a home."

Bao was silent. Aunt Han continued:

"So we parted. He followed his road. I followed mine."

Bao:

"He never stopped loving you."

Aunt Han:

"Love was never the problem."

Yuelan pressed a hand against her mouth. She had never imagined Aunt Han as a young woman wandering the Jianghu with a swordsman.
Never imagined her as an imperial spy. Never imagined that beneath the ordinary life of the Returning Swallow lay a past filled with secrets and blood.

Bao spoke again:

"They sent hunters after me. I lost them three days ago."

Aunt Han went still:

"Are you certain?"

Bao:

"Han, I've survived thirty years in the Jianghu."

Aunt Han:

"That wasn't my question."

Bao sighed:

"I'm certain."

Aunt Han rose:

"Then we must leave tonight."

Yuelan stepped away from the wall. She had to tell Xiaoyu. Had to ask Aunt Han—

A scream erupted outside.

"FIRE!"

Then came the sound of breaking glass. And the first arrow struck the inn. The stable roof caught fire almost immediately. A second flaming arrow shattered against a wine barrel near the courtyard. A third buried itself in the throat of Old Wen, the stable keeper. Yuelan saw him fall through the window. For a moment, she simply stared. Old Wen had taught her to saddle horses. He had helped repair the fences she destroyed. He had sung terribly whenever he drank too much. Now he lay motionless beneath the stable lantern. Another arrow struck the roof; Then another. The Returning Swallow erupted into chaos. Customers screamed. Tables overturned. Horses broke free from their stalls. Smoke poured through the corridors. From the road emerged a dozen cloaked figures wearing dark masks. They moved with disciplined silence.

Hunters.

One raised a hand:

"Find Han Wei."

Another asked,

"And the witnesses?"

The leader answered without hesitation:

"Leave none."

Yuelan felt her blood turn cold. She ran toward the courtyard. The first assassin vaulted over the wall. Her five swords slid from their scabbards. He carried a curved saber and a short dagger. Yuelan raised her arm. Steel flashed forward. The man barely managed to parry. Water followed, sweeping beneath his guard. He staggered. Yuelan twisted her wrist. The steel blade spun. Blood sprayed across the stones. The assassin fell, and Yuelan froze. She had cut practice dummies, fought wooden targets, and she had imagined countless glorious duels, but she had never killed a man. His blood spread across the courtyard, then another assassin charged. A sword intercepted him. Bao appeared through the smoke. His blade flashed twice and the attacker fell.

Bao seized Yuelan's shoulder:

"Where's Han?"

Yuelan:

"She was with you!"

Bao:

"She left through the rear passage!"

Yuelan:

"I haven't seen her!"

Bao cursed:

“Kào”

He looked toward the burning inn.

"She knows how to disappear. Come!”

He dragged Yuelan toward the rear gate. Two assassins blocked their path. Bao struck the first across the wrist, then drove his sword into the man's chest.

Yuelan swept her arm. The earth blade smashed into the second attacker, throwing him against the wall. They burst through the gate and ran into the pine forest. Behind them, the Returning Swallow burned. They had gone perhaps two hundred paces when Yuelan stopped.

Bao turned:

"What are you doing?"

Yuelan:

"Xiaoyu."

Bao :

"Han would have taken her. Your aunt can take care of herself."

Yuelan:

"And the others? … The villagers, the workers, and the travelers. They're still there!"

Bao :

"We cannot save everyone.""

Yuelan:

"We haven't even tried!"

Bao grabbed her shoulders:

"Listen to me, girl. Those people are trained killers. They came prepared. They'll burn the entire inn to erase every witness."

Yuelan:

"Then they'll kill Xiaoyu!"

Bao:

"Han may already have her!"

Her voice broke:

"You don't know!"

Bao looked toward the flames. For a long moment, he said nothing. Then he shook his head:

"Your aunt will murder me for this."

Yuelan stared.

Bao drew his sword:

"What? … We go back. Find your sister and whoever remains alive. Get them out. Then run."

Yuelan's eyes filled:

"Thank you."

Bao pointed his sword at her:

"But listen carefully. We aren't going back to win a heroic battle. When I tell you to run, you run."

Yuelan:

"Understood."

He studied her, then sighed:

"You're just like your mother."

Together, they returned toward the burning inn. The courtyard had become a battlefield. The plum tree beside the well was on fire. The stables had collapsed. Bodies lay scattered among shattered jars and broken furniture. Yuelan recognized several faces:

A merchant who had ordered wine that morning.

A kitchen worker who had helped prepare lunch.

Old Madam Liu's husband.

She forced herself to keep moving. They entered through the kitchen. Two assassins stood beside the cook's body. Bao killed the first before he could turn. Yuelan struck the second with wood, sweeping his legs from beneath him before steel drove into his shoulder. He screamed, and she hesitated.

Bao finished the fight. "Don't stop!" he shouted.

They pushed through the smoke.

Yuelan:

"XIAOYU!"

No answer.

"XIAOYU!"

A faint voice came from behind a collapsed shelving unit.

"Jiejie?"

Yuelan spun. There, crouched behind stacked wine barrels, was Xiaoyu. Her face was blackened with soot, and a kitchen knife trembled in her hand. Behind Xiaoyu huddled more than a dozen villagers and travelers.

Xiaoyu ran toward her:

"Jiejie!"

Yuelan caught her in a fierce embrace:

"You're alive."

Xiaoyu:

"Of course I'm alive!"

Yuelan:

"Where's Aunt Han?"

Xiaoyu shook her head:

"She told me to hide everyone here. She said she'd come back."

Yuelan:

"When?"

Xiaoyu:

"Before the fire spread."

Yuelan looked toward Bao.

Bao expression darkened:

"She's drawing them away."

Yuelan swallowed, then turned toward the villagers:

"There's a path through the rear courtyard. It leads toward the river."

One of the travelers shook his head:

"Armed men are guarding the gate!"

Bao lifted his sword:

"Then we'll open it."

The first wave came through the kitchen doorway. Six assassins.

Yuelan raised both arms. Steel and water crossed before her. Arrows shattered against the spinning blades. She stepped forward, her feet tracing the opening movements of the Spring Lotus Dance. Fire swept across the doorway. One assassin fell screaming. Earth struck another's shield with enough force to throw him backward. Wood curved around a third man's guard, slicing into his thigh.

Bao charged through the opening. His swordsmanship was nothing like Yuelan's. There was no beauty in it. He fought with brutal efficiency, striking wrists, knees, throats, and exposed joints. Every motion had a purpose. Every opening was exploited.

Yuelan, by contrast, moved like a flower caught in a storm. Her sleeves flowed, feet turned, and her swords traced graceful arcs through the smoke.

She spun beneath a saber and swept her arm outward, and steel followed; an assassin fell. She rotated her left wrist and water circled behind another attacker, striking from an unexpected angle. For a moment, she felt powerful, almost invincible. Then an assassin hurled a handful of iron needles. She tried to redirect her blades, but it was too late. A needle buried itself in her shoulder. Pain shattered her concentration. The swords clattered to the floor. Yuelan stumbled, and a masked swordsman rushed her.

Bao intercepted him; Bao shouted:

> "Your center! You're controlling the blades with your arms!"

Yuelan gasped:

> "What?"

Bao:

> "Your Qi comes from your dantian! Move from your waist, not your shoulders!"

She gritted her teeth. Her mother had written the same lesson countless times. The feet root the body. The waist carries the breath. The hand gives the command. She planted her foot and turned from the waist. She breathed and the

five blades recovered. She moved again. This time, they followed more smoothly. But the attackers kept coming, and by the time they reached the rear courtyard, Yuelan's clothes were soaked in sweat and blood. Bao had a deep cut across his arm. The villagers rushed toward the river path. One by one, they slipped through the gate.

Yuelan and Bao held the passage. At first, ten attackers came, then more. The fire sword grew sluggish, Earth felt unbearably heavy, and Water trembled. Yuelan's breathing turned ragged. Her Qi reserves were nearly exhausted. Still, she fought. A saberman charged and Wood struck his knee, and Steel crossed his chest. Another attacked from behind. Yuelan turned too slowly, and his shoulder slammed into her. They fell together. Her head struck the stones. She saw the world spin, and the assassin pinned her beneath his weight. His knee crushed her sword arm.

His hand closed around her throat:

"Pretty tricks," he hissed.

Yuelan struggled. The five blades dropped to the ground. The man drew a dagger. Its tip hovered above her heart:

"Let's see you dance now."

A kitchen knife protruded from his back. Xiaoyu stood behind him, both hands gripping the handle. Her face was white with terror:

"GET OFF MY SISTER!"

She twisted the knife. The man screamed. Yuelan shoved him aside.

"Xiaoyu!"

Her younger sister looked at her. For one heartbeat, she smiled.

"See? I told you I could—"

A bowstring snapped. The arrow came from the burning veranda. It struck Xiaoyu in the chest. The sound was small. A dull impact beneath the roar of the flames. Xiaoyu looked down. Her fingers touched the arrow shaft:

"Oh."

Her knees buckled.

Yuelan caught her:

"No."

Xiaoyu blinked:

"Jiejie?"

Yuelan:

"No, no, no..."

Yuelan pressed her hands against the wound. Blood soaked her fingers:

"Don't move. You're going to be fine."

Xiaoyu tried to breathe. A wet gasp escaped her lips:

"Does it... look bad?"

Yuelan shook her head:

"No. It's nothing. Aunt Han will fix it. She knows medicine. She'll fix it."

Xiaoyu's eyes searched her face.

"You're crying."

Yuelan:

"I'm not."

Xiaoyu:

"You always cry... when you're angry."

Yuelan

"Stop talking."

Xiaoyu smiled faintly.

"Remember... when we stole Auntie's wine?"

Yuelan:

"Xiaoyu..."

Xiaoyu:

"You blamed... the cat."

Yuelan:

"Please."

Xiaoyu:

"There wasn't... a cat."

Xiaoyu's fingers curled around Yuelan.

"Jiejie… Don't... be alone."

Yuelan's breath caught; Xiaoyu looked toward the burning inn.

"I wanted... to brew..."

Yuelan:

"What? Xiaoyu?"

Xiaoyu:

"...our own wine..."

Yuelan stared.

"Xiaoyu?"

No answer.

"Xiaoyu?"

"XIAOYU!"

Yuelan screamed until her throat tore. She held her sister against her chest, rocking back and forth as though she could somehow return warmth to the body in her arms. The world around her vanished. There were no assassins, burning buildings, or war; only Xiaoyu. The little girl who had followed her everywhere. Who had laughed at her mistakes, dreamed of becoming a respectable wine merchant, and would never grow older than nineteen.

Bao:

“Yuelan! Run!”

No answer.

“Yuelan! Are you listening?!”

A hand seized Yuelan's collar.

"GET UP!"

Bao’s face was covered in blood. More assassins were approaching.

"We have to go!"

Yuelan clutched Xiaoyu:

"No!"

Bao:

"Yuelan!"

Yuelan:

"I CAN'T LEAVE HER!"

Bao looked at the dead girl. For one moment, the hardened swordsman disappeared. He looked like a tired old man who had lived long enough to recognize another failure.

"I'm sorry," he whispered.

Then he lifted Yuelan from the ground, and she fought him. She kicked, screamed, and reached desperately toward her sister. Bao dragged her through the smoke, picking up the five swords, and leaving the makeshift scabbard behind. Behind them, burning timber collapsed across the courtyard. And Han Yuelan learned that the Jianghu was not a place where heroes always saved those they loved. Sometimes, survival meant leaving them behind.

The wine cellar was filled with smoke. Bao stumbled down the stone staircase, dragging Yuelan behind him. His breathing was ragged. Yuelan barely noticed. She stared at her hands. Xiaoyu's blood had dried between her fingers:

Yuelan whispered:

"We left her… We left her there."

Bao:

"I know."

Yuelan:

"She's alone."

Bao closed his eyes:

"I know."

Yuelan looked at him:

"I promised our parents I'd protect her."

Footsteps echoed above. Bao dropped Yuelan's swords on the ground and drew his sword.

"Stay behind me."

The first assassin descended the stairs. Bao killed him. The second followed, and Yuelan raised her hand. Steel flashed forward, and the man fell. The third and fourth attacked together. Bao intercepted one, and Yuelan struck the other with fire. But her movements were slow, and her Qi was nearly spent. One attacker slashed her left arm and she cried out. Bao kicked him backward.

Bao, with a concerned look:

"You're exhausted!"

Yuelan:

"Then I'll fight exhausted!"

Bao:

"You can barely stand!"

Yuelan:

"Then I won't have far to fall."

Bao looked at her. For a brief moment, he smiled sadly:

"Your mother really did raise a stubborn daughter."

Then a voice echoed from the staircase.

"Enough!"

The assassins withdrew. A figure descended slowly into the cellar. Unlike the others, he wore a dark blue cloak embroidered with silver thread. A bronze mask covered the upper half of his face. His movements were calm and deliberate. He carried a narrow sword concealed within a black walking staff.

The man stopped beneath a hanging lantern:

"Bao."

Bao stiffened:

"...You."

The stranger removed his mask. He was a refined-looking man in his forties, with a thin scar running from his temple to his jaw. He smiled.

"How many years has it been?"

Bao raised his sword:

"Not enough."

The stranger glanced toward Yuelan:

"Ah. The elder niece."

Yuelan:

"Who are you?"

The man bowed politely.

"Inspector Wang Shouren. Formerly of the Imperial Bureau of Hidden Affairs."

He gestured toward the cellar.

"What an extraordinary place. To think that She Who Wears Many Faces spent her retirement brewing wine."

Yuelan stared:

"So it's true."

Wang smiled:

"Your aunt was quite remarkable in her day."

Yuelan:

"Where is she?"

Wang:

"That is precisely what I hoped you would tell me."

Yuelan:

"You destroyed my home. You murdered innocent people."

Wang:

"An unfortunate necessity."

Yuelan:

"You killed my sister."

Wang:

"Collateral damage. How regrettable."

Yuelan raised both hands:

"I'll kill you."

Bao caught her arm:

"No."

Yuelan shook him off.

"I'LL KILL HIM!"

She attacked. Her five swords surged forward in the (Liánhuá Chūzhàn Shì) Opening Lotus formation. Steel and water crossed, and Fire descended while Wood curved behind Wang and Earth swept toward his legs. Wang watched calmly, then raised two fingers. Wang tapped his cane and a pulse of Qi spread from his hand.

He said calmly:

“Limbo”

The five blades stopped … not slowed but stopped. Yuelan gasped. Wang stepped forward, almost instantly closing the distance, and struck her with an open palm. The blow landed against her sternum. Her breath vanished, and she flew backward into a wine jar. Clay shattered, and dark liquor flooded the floor. Yuelan collapsed, coughing blood.

Wang examined his sleeve.

"Extraordinary potential. Sadly, potential is not mastery."

Bao charged, and his sword flashed toward Wang’s throat. Wang turned, and two fingers caught the blade. Qi shrieked against steel. Bao twisted, broke free, and struck again. For several breaths, the cellar rang with the sound of steel hitting the floor as Bao’s sword struck the furniture as Wang evaded. Bao was fast, faster than Yuelan had imagined. His swordsmanship was relentless, brutal, and devastatingly precise. But Wang barely moved; he deflected every attack and then struck Bao across the chest. The old swordsman staggered. Blood stained his robe.

Wang remarks:

"You're slower."

Bao:

"I'm older."

Wang:

"Age has made you sentimental."

Bao spat blood:

"No. Age has made me tired of men like you."

He attacked again. Wang sighed and then drew his black sword. Their blades collided. A violent shockwave cracked the stone floor. Bao pulled away to strike again. Wang parried the attack and riposted by tapping Bao on the knee. Bao fell to the floor as his knees burned from the dark Qi. Yuelan struggled upright.

Wang looked at her.

"Little dancer, did your aunt never teach you that there are mountains beyond mountains?"

He gestured toward Bao.

"This man was once feared throughout the northern martial circles.

And now?

He smiled.

"Now he's merely old."

With one kick, Bao flew across the cellar. The old man struck a pillar and fell. Yuelan screamed.

"BAO!"

She lunged at Wang. Wang pointed his palm at Yuelan, a pressure pulse throwing her backward. The world spun, then she was on the floor. Her five swords lay scattered.

Wang approached:

"Where is Han Wei?"

Yuelan spat blood:

"Go to hell."

Wang sighed:

"Very well."

He raised his sword. But hesitated and turned around when hear the thundering footsteps.

Wang cursed:

“Kào”

Bao, at high speed, threw his whole body weight into Wang’s right side, sending him flying away, hitting the left wall, and destroying a shelf of wine jars. Bao roared

"RUN!"

He seized Yuelan and dragged her toward the far wall. There stood the old wooden freight elevator. Its platform could carry several large wine jars, and its heavy counterweight system led toward an upper storage building beyond the inn. Bao shoved Yuelan onto the platform. While Wang was still dazed, Bao picked up Yuelan's swords.

Yuelan:

"What are you doing?"

Bao reached for the release lever. Yuelan caught his sleeve.

"No."

Bao:

"Listen to me."

Bao gripped her shoulders. His eyes were suddenly calm.

"Your aunt is alive. Because if Wang had captured her, he would not be searching this cellar."

Yuelan:

"Then we find her together."

Bao smiled sadly:

"That would be nice."

Yuelan:

"Bao..."

Bao looked at her:

"Your aunt wanted you girls to live ordinary lives. She knew what waited beyond these mountains. Your mother would have been proud of you."

Then he pulled the lever. The platform lurched upward. Yuelan stumbled:

"BAO!"

She reached down. He stepped backward, just beyond her grasp. Wang, who was slowly getting up, yelled across the room:

“Sentiment, Bao! Oh heavens, you are old!”

Bao turned around to face Wang. Bao speak loudly

"Yuelan! When you find Han, tell her I finally paid my wine debt."

Wang took a step, instantly closing the distance. A black blade entered through his chest. Bao groaned and grabbed the blade. Wang stood in front of him, one hand on the sword hilt, the other at the end, trying to push the sword further into Bao's chest.

Wang said quietly:

"Sentiment. Really is a terrible weakness."

Bao looked down at the blade impaling his chest. Then, astonishingly, he smiled. Bao moved his hands closed around Wang’s wrist.

"You're right."

Qi began gathering around him. Not the elegant, controlled Qi of the Fivefold Dance. This was raw and violent. A lifetime of cultivation forced into one final act. The flames dancing across the spilled liquor bent toward him. Air rushed through the cellar.

Wang’s expression changed:

"What are you—"

Bao laughed:

"Getting old."

The flames brightened.

"Getting tired."

The very air shimmered with heat as Bao forced his Qi into the burning vapors rising from the shattered jars.

"And getting..."

He tightened his grip.

"...one last drink."

Wang tried to pull free, but it was too late. Bao released everything. The cellar became a sun. The explosion hurled the freight elevator upward. Its chains screamed, and stone shattered. A column of fire surged through the shaft beneath Yuelan. Heat seared her skin, and the world became light and then darkness.

The survivors returned when the smoke cleared. Only a handful had escaped the massacre:

Old Madam Liu.

Several workers.

Two merchants.

A family traveling south.

Three children.

They searched the ruins for the dead. The bodies they recovered were buried upon a hillside overlooking the valley. Some graves held remains. Others held only ashes, clothing, or personal belongings. A grave was made for Old Wen. Another for the cook. Another for Bao, whose broken sword hilt was recovered from the rubble. A small grave was made for Xiaoyu. And beside it, another was made for Han Yuelan.

The villagers had seen Bao drag her into the cellar. They had seen the explosion. Nobody believed she could have survived. Upon her grave, they placed a simple wooden marker and the makeshift scabbard.

HAN YUELAN
BELOVED DAUGHTER OF THE HAN FAMILY
WHO FOUGHT SO OTHERS MIGHT LIVE

When the rain stopped, the survivors prepared a funeral. They gathered what wine remained in the nearby storehouses, burned incense, and invited the surviving families to pay their respects. A stranger arrived on the seventh day after the fire. Her hair was short and hidden beneath a broad bamboo hat. A faded gray cloak concealed most of her body. She walked with a slight limp. Her left arm was stiff. A burn scar marked her neck.

The villagers did not recognize her. At the edge of the funeral gathering, Old Madam Liu approached:

> "Honored wanderer," she said, bowing. "Did you know the Han family?"

The wanderer's throat tightened. She lowered her head.

> "Yes."

Madam Liu:

> "They were good people."

The wanderer:

> "I know."

Madam Liu:

> "The elder girl was a martial artist. Very talented. She stayed behind to protect us."

The wanderer said nothing.

Madam Liu wiped her eyes:

> "Her younger sister died trying to save her."

The wanderer's fingers curled beneath her sleeves.

Madam Liu continued:

> "We could not recover the elder one's body. The explosion destroyed everything."

The wanderer looked toward the graves.

"May I pay my respects?"

Madam Liu stepped aside.

"Of course."

The wanderer walked slowly up the hillside. Fourteen graves stood beneath the gray autumn sky. She passed Old Wen's, the cook's, the merchants', and Bao's. Then she stopped. Two graves stood beside one another: Han Xiaoyu and Han Yuelan. The wanderer stared at the scabbard and the name carved into the wooden marker. The wanderer knelt beside Xiaoyu's resting place. Someone had placed a pair of embroidered shoes upon the mound. The wanderer bowed until her forehead touched the earth. Beside her, the funeral ceremony began. Madam Liu poured three cups of wine upon the ground.

"One for the road they walked,"

She poured the first.

"One for the people they loved."

The second.

"And one for the home they can no longer return to."

The third.

The wanderer remained kneeling. When the mourners began to leave, she took a small ceramic cup from her bag. The wanderer placed it beside Xiaoyu's grave. Then she reached for the wine gourd at her waist. Inside was the last surviving batch of Returning Swallow Wine. The wanderer poured a small amount into the cup. The familiar fragrance of plum blossoms rose into the air.

The wanderer whispered:

"For you."

The wind stirred the grass. She turned toward Bao's grave. From her bag, she withdrew a single copper coin. She set it upon his marker.

The wanderer murmured:

"You paid your debt.”

Then she bowed, for a long time. When she finally rose, the sun had begun to set. The funeral was over and the mourners were returning to their homes. Only the wanderer remained. She approached Yuelan's grave. The wooden marker stood slightly crooked. Someone had placed a small bundle of wildflowers beneath it. The wanderer stared at the carved characters.

HAN YUELAN.

She reached out and touched the name. Then slowly withdrew her hand. Behind her, footsteps approached. Madam Liu stood a short distance away and had been observing for the last few hours.

"Honored wanderer."

The wanderer turned:

"Yes?"

The old woman looked toward the graves:

"Thank you for coming. The Han family would have appreciated knowing they were remembered."

The wanderer bowed:

"They will be."

Madam Liu hesitated.

"May I ask your name?"

The wanderer looked toward the wooden marker. Then toward Xiaoyu's grave. Then toward the blackened valley where the inn had once stood. Finally, she shook her head.

"I have no name."

Madam Liu studied her. A sad smile crossed her face.

"Then I hope the road gives you one worth carrying."

The wanderer bowed again.

"Thank you."

The old woman departed. The wanderer stood alone among the graves. Above her, a swallow circled once beneath the darkening sky before flying south.

She watched until it disappeared. Two days later, a lone traveler walked along the eastern mountain road. She wore a broad bamboo hat, a gray cloak, and a faded blue sash. Across her back rested five polished scabbards, crudely bound together with leather straps. At her waist hung a wine gourd. The wanderer walked without haste. She had no destination yet but two purposes.